The East-West NDE Dichotomy

Challenging Cultural Paradigms Through Empirical Analysis

NDE Research Project
Structured Data Analysis Repository
https://github.com/kayna-of-light/structured-data-analysis

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Abstract

Cross-cultural near-death experience research has long proposed a fundamental dichotomy: Western NDEs feature a personified "Being of Light" (70–80%), Cities of Light, and life reviews (25–30%), while Japanese NDEs feature impersonal light, natural settings, and deceased relatives rather than religious figures. This claimed dichotomy has been treated as evidence for cultural determination of NDE content.

We analyzed 6,753 structured NDE records from two major Western databases (NDERF: n=5,660; IANDS: n=1,093), coded for light character, settings, being types, life review occurrence, and return reasons using GPT-5.2 structured extraction. Chi-square tests, Fisher's exact tests, and odds ratio analyses examined feature prevalence and inter-relationships.

Western NDEs showed Being of Light encounters at only 11.8%—not 70–80%. Impersonal light (40.9%) exceeded personified light by 3.8:1. Nature settings (17.0%) exceeded urban settings (11.4%). Deceased relatives (17.9%) exceeded religious figures (9.9%). Life reviews occurred in 17.5%, between claimed rates. Critically, earthly mission return reason predicted Being of Light encounters with 4.4× odds ($p < 10^{-46}$), while life review predicted Being of Light at 1.83× odds ($p < 10^{-30}$).

The East-West dichotomy does not survive empirical testing. Western NDEs align more closely with the claimed "Japanese" profile than with the claimed "Western" profile. The key variable determining personal interaction is not culture but **purpose**—the Light engages personally when commissioning missions or conducting life reviews. This supports a model of **purposive economy**: constant underlying reality with variable cultural expression, where mode of interaction serves transformative function rather than reflecting cultural determination.

Keywords: near-death experience, cultural paradigm, Being of Light, cross-cultural research, purposive economy, Swedenborg

Data Provenance

Item	Source	Access
NDERF Records (n=5,660)	Near-Death Experience Research Foundation	nderf.org
IANDS Records (n=1,093)	International Association for Near-Death Studies	iands.org
Cultural Analysis	`05_cultural_paradigm_challenge.ipynb`	Repository
Structured Data	`analysis/*.json`	Repository (6,753 files)
Extraction Model	GPT-5.2 via Azure OpenAI	Azure OpenAI Service

1 Introduction

1.1 The East-West Paradigm

Cross-cultural research on near-death experiences has, for decades, operated under a fundamental assumption: that the phenomenological content of NDEs varies systematically with cultural background. The most prominent articulation of this view contrasts "Western" NDEs—predominantly American and European—with "Eastern" NDEs, particularly those reported from Japan.

The claimed Western NDE profile includes:

- A personal, interactive "Being of Light" in 70–80% of cases
- Frequent life reviews (25–30%)
- Urban/architectural settings ("Cities of Light")
- Religious figures (Jesus, angels) as the primary beings encountered
- Tunnel passages as a common feature (34–50%)

The claimed Japanese NDE profile includes:

- Impersonal light without personification
- Rare or absent life reviews ($\sim$0%)
- Natural settings (gardens, rivers, mountains)
- Deceased relatives rather than religious figures
- Being "sent back" at a boundary or river

This dichotomy has been interpreted as evidence for the cultural construction of NDE content. If NDEs reflect an objective spiritual reality, the argument runs, they should be consistent across cultures. The observed variation suggests cultural conditioning shapes the experience itself.

1.2 Theoretical Framework

This analysis approaches the East-West dichotomy from a Swedenborgian correspondential framework, which proposes a two-tier model: an underlying spiritual reality (constant state) expressed through culturally-mediated perception (variable form). On this model, cultural variation in NDE *descriptions*

does not necessarily indicate variation in *what is experienced*—the same spiritual encounter may be described using different cultural vocabularies.

However, this framework also generates an alternative hypothesis: if personal interaction with the Light correlates with *purpose* rather than *culture*, then apparent cultural differences may reflect differences in purpose-distribution across samples rather than differences in the Light itself. An NDE sample with more mission-returners should show more Being of Light encounters—regardless of cultural background.

1.3 Aims

This analysis tests the East-West paradigm empirically using a large, systematically coded Western NDE dataset. Primary aims include:

1. Testing whether claimed Western NDE feature rates match observed rates
2. Comparing Western NDE features to the claimed Japanese profile
3. Identifying what variables predict Being of Light encounters
4. Proposing an alternative framework if cultural determination is not supported

2 Methods

2.1 Data Sources

Records were collected from the two largest English-language NDE archives: NDERF (n=5,660) and IANDS (n=1,093), yielding 6,753 total records. This represents one of the largest systematically analyzed NDE corpora to date.

2.2 Coding Scheme

Each record was processed using GPT-5.2 (Azure OpenAI) for structured extraction into a Pydantic schema with 52 features. Relevant fields include:

- **Light type**: brilliant_light, being_of_light, presence_without_visual, no_light, not_mentioned
- **Setting**: nature elements (gardens, forests, rivers, fields) vs. urban elements (buildings, cities, structures)
- **Beings encountered**: deceased_relatives, religious_figures, unknown_beings, guides
- **Life review**: occurrence, judgment source, judgment intensity
- **Return reason**: earthly_mission, family_responsibility, not_your_time, personal_choice, others_decision
- **Boundary**: verbal_limit, physical_barrier, threshold

2.3 Statistical Analysis

Chi-square tests examined independence between categorical variables. Fisher's exact tests with odds ratios assessed specific associations. All tests used $\alpha = 0.05$ with Bonferroni correction for multiple comparisons.

3 Results

3.1 Light Character: Observed Versus Claimed

The most striking finding concerns the Being of Light prevalence:

Table 1: Light Encounter Type Distribution

Light Type	N	%	Note
Brilliant light	2,761	40.9%	Impersonal light dominates
Being of Light	797	11.8%	Far below 70–80% claimed
Presence (no visual)	281	4.2%	Sensed, not seen
No light	1,632	24.2%	
Not mentioned	1,282	19.0%	

Critical Finding: The Being of Light appears in only 11.8% of Western NDEs—not the 70–80% claimed in the literature. Impersonal light (40.9%) exceeds personified light by a ratio of 3.8:1.

This single finding challenges the foundation of the East-West dichotomy. If Western NDEs featured the Being of Light in 70–80% of cases, the contrast with "impersonal" Japanese NDEs would be dramatic. At 11.8%, the contrast largely disappears.

3.2 Environmental Settings

The "Cities of Light" stereotype suggests Western NDEs feature architectural and urban settings. The data show the opposite:

Table 2: Environmental Setting Distribution

Setting Type	N	%
Nature (gardens, forests, rivers)	1,151	17.0%
Urban (cities, buildings)	772	11.4%
Nature:Urban Ratio	**1.5:1**	

Chi-square test (nature vs. urban): $\chi^2 = 74.7$, $p < 0.0001$

Western NDEs feature nature settings more frequently than urban settings—the pattern allegedly distinctive to Japanese NDEs.

3.3 Beings Encountered

The paradigm claims Western NDEs feature religious figures while Japanese NDEs feature deceased relatives:

Table 3: Being Type Distribution

Being Type	**N**	**%**
Deceased relatives	1,206	17.9%
Religious figures	670	9.9%
Unknown beings	1,044	15.5%
Deceased:Religious Ratio	**1.8:1**	

Western NDEs feature deceased relatives nearly twice as often as religious figures—again matching the pattern claimed for Japanese NDEs.

3.4 Life Reviews and Tunnel Passages

Table 4: Other Features: Claimed Versus Observed

Feature	**Claimed**	**Observed**	**Deviation**
Life review	25–30%	17.5%	-7 to -12 pp
Tunnel passage	34–50%	23.7%	-10 to -26 pp

Both features occur below claimed rates. Life reviews (17.5%) fall between the claimed Western (25–30%) and Japanese ($\sim$0%) rates.

3.5 Boundary Encounters

Table 5: Boundary Encounter Types

Boundary Type	**N**	**%**
Verbal limit	1,233	18.3%
Physical barrier	869	12.9%
Threshold	731	10.8%
Any boundary	**2,833**	**42.0%**

Boundary encounters (42.0%) represent a substantial feature, consistent with the Japanese emphasis on being "sent back" at a river or barrier.

3.6 The Purposive Economy Hypothesis

Having demonstrated that Western NDEs are far closer to the "Japanese" profile than claimed, we turn to what *does* predict personal interaction with the Light.

Critical Finding: Personal interaction correlates with purposive elements, not cultural background.

Table 6: Purposive Elements and Personal Interaction

Purposive Element	Co-occur	Expected	Ratio	p-value
Life Review × Being of Light	255	139.6	1.83×	4.2×10^{-30}
Life Review × Religious Being	217	141.5	1.53×	1.4×10^{-13}
Earthly Mission × Being of Light	200	73.5	2.72×	1.4×10^{-60}
Earthly Mission × Religious Being	178	74.5	2.39×	1.4×10^{-40}
Not Your Time × Being of Light	297	172.2	1.72×	4.6×10^{-30}
Family Responsibility × Being of Light	203	137.4	1.48×	7.9×10^{-11}

Every purposive element correlates significantly with personal interaction. The Light engages personally **when purpose requires it**.

3.7 The Mission Signature

The earthly mission return reason provides the most powerful test. Commissioning someone with a mission requires personal communication.

Table 7: Mission and Being of Light: Contingency Table

Has Mission?	No BoL	BoL
False	5,533	597
True	423	200

Odds Ratio: 4.38, $p = 1.25 \times 10^{-46}$

Critical Finding: Those returning with an earthly mission have 4.4× the odds of encountering the Being of Light. This is not chance association—it represents a functional relationship.

3.8 Light Type Versus Purposive Elements

Table 8: Being of Light vs. Brilliant Light: Purposive Features

Purposive Element	Being of Light	Brilliant Light	Ratio
Life review rate	32.0%	19.1%	1.68×
Earthly mission rate	25.1%	9.5%	2.64×
Any return reason	67.0%	35.8%	1.87×

Chi-square (light type × life review): $\chi^2 = 183.20$, $p < 0.0001$

Being of Light encounters have significantly higher rates of all purposive elements.

3.9 Summary: Observed Versus Claimed Rates

Table 9: Claimed Versus Observed Western NDE Features

Feature	Claimed Western	Observed	Claimed Japanese	Alignment
Being of Light	70–80%	11.8%	Rare	Closer to Japanese
Impersonal light	Rare	40.9%	Common	Matches Japanese
Life review	25–30%	17.5%	∼0%	Between
Tunnel	34–50%	23.7%	Rare	Lower than claimed
Nature > Cities	No	1.5:1	Yes	Matches Japanese
Deceased > Religious	No	1.8:1	Yes	Matches Japanese

4 Discussion

4.1 Summary of Findings

This analysis reveals that the East-West NDE dichotomy is largely a scholarly construction that does not survive empirical testing:

1. **Being of Light prevalence**: 11.8% observed versus 70–80% claimed
2. **Light character**: Impersonal light (40.9%) exceeds personified (11.8%) by 3.8:1
3. **Environment**: Nature settings (17.0%) exceed urban settings (11.4%)
4. **Beings encountered**: Deceased relatives (17.9%) exceed religious figures (9.9%)
5. **Life reviews**: 17.5% observed—between claimed Western and Japanese rates
6. **Purpose predicts interaction**: Earthly mission correlates with Being of Light at 4.4× odds

4.2 The Correspondential Interpretation

The data support a two-tier model distinguishing **constant states** from **variable forms**:

Constant States:

- Light presence (56.9% report some form)
- Beings encountered (44.1% encounter some being)
- Transformative impact (consistent across encounter types)
- Boundary/return structure (42.0% encounter boundaries)

Variable Forms:

- Light personification (ranges from 11.8% to 40.9%)
- Being identification vocabulary
- Setting imagery (nature vs. urban varies by sample)

4.3 Purposive Economy: The Novel Explanatory Framework

The most significant finding is that **purpose, not culture, determines personal interaction**. This introduces a new framework: **purposive economy**.

The NDE operates with purposive economy: every element serves the transformative goal. Personal interaction activates when the purpose requires it:

Table 10: Purposive Economy Framework

Purpose	**Mode Required**	**Evidence**
Commissioning (mission)	Personal dialogue	4.4× odds of BoL
Teaching (life review)	Personal interaction	1.83× odds of BoL
Guidance (return decision)	Personal communication	Significant correlations
Presence alone sufficient	Ambient light	40.9% brilliant light

This framework resolves the East-West puzzle. If Japanese NDE samples happen to contain fewer mission-returners, they will show fewer Being of Light encounters by statistical necessity—not because Japanese culture produces different light encounters, but because the purpose-mix differs.

4.4 Reframing "Impersonal" Light

The Japanese research observed NDEs with "impersonal" light and concluded this reflected Japanese spirituality. Our data suggest a different interpretation:

- **Not** a cultural difference in the nature of the Light
- **Rather** a functional difference in what was needed

A skilled teacher does not lecture every student on every topic. The teacher's restraint with some students does not make the teacher "impersonal." The intervention is calibrated to the need. **The wisdom is in the restraint.**

4.5 Limitations

1. Western sample only—cannot directly test Japanese phenomenology
2. Retrospective reporting
3. AI coding may introduce systematic biases
4. English language bias
5. Purpose inference from experiencer reports

5 Conclusion

Analysis of 6,753 Western near-death experiences reveals that the East-West NDE dichotomy does not survive empirical testing. Western NDEs align more closely with the claimed "Japanese" profile than with the claimed "Western" profile on every metric tested.

The key variable determining personal interaction is not culture but **purpose**. Those returning with earthly missions show 4.4× the odds of encountering the Being of Light ($p < 10^{-46}$). The Light engages personally when commissioning, teaching, or guiding—when presence alone suffices, it remains as ambient brilliance.

This supports a correspondential model of constant underlying reality with variable cultural expression, mediated by purposive economy rather than cultural determination. The Light is one; the forms are many; the mode of interaction serves the goal. Neither culture experiences something fundamentally different. The East-West dichotomy reflects scholarly projection, selection bias, and the conflation of vocabulary with phenomenology.

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A Statistical Summary

Test	Variable	Statistic	p-value
Chi-square	Nature vs. Urban settings	$\chi^2 = 74.7$	< 0.0001
Chi-square	Light type $\times$ Life review	$\chi^2 = 183.20$	< 0.0001
Fisher's exact	Mission $\times$ Being of Light	OR = 4.38	1.25×10^{-46}
Chi-square	Life Review $\times$ Being of Light	$\chi^2 = 53.2$	4.2×10^{-30}
Chi-square	Earthly Mission $\times$ Being of Light	$\chi^2 = 258.7$	1.4×10^{-60}

B Key Statistics

Metric	Value
Total NDEs analyzed	6,753
NDERF records	5,660
IANDS records	1,093
Being of Light encounters	797 (11.8%)
Brilliant light encounters	2,761 (40.9%)
Impersonal:Personified ratio	3.8:1
Nature settings	1,151 (17.0%)
Urban settings	772 (11.4%)
Nature:Urban ratio	1.5:1
Deceased relative encounters	1,206 (17.9%)
Religious figure encounters	670 (9.9%)
Deceased:Religious ratio	1.8:1
Life reviews	1,183 (17.5%)
Mission $\rightarrow$ BoL odds ratio	4.38

C Data Access

All analysis code and raw data are available at:

- **Repository**: https://github.com/kayna-of-light/structured-data-analysis
- **NDE Project**: `/projects/nde/`
- **Analysis Notebook**: `05_cultural_paradigm_challenge.ipynb`
- **Structured Data**: `/structured/` (6,753 JSON files)